

The Job Search Playbook

Document 6 of 6 — Resume, Applications, Interviews, Negotiation

This is the reference document for your daily job-search hour, which begins on Day 29 (October 2). The daily plan tells you *when* to work on the search; this document tells you *how*. Work through Sections 1 to 5 in order during the first week of October, then use Sections 6 to 9 as reference for the rest of the plan.

Section 1 — Rewriting Your Resume for Backend Engineering

Your current resume is a strong QA resume. The work now is to make it a backend engineering resume without inventing anything. Three changes do most of the work.

- **Reframe Cognizant honestly.** You genuinely built automation in Python, investigated production incidents by reading logs and telemetry, and resolved integration problems between legacy and modern platforms. Lead with that engineering work. Keep it truthful — do not claim you were a backend developer — but stop letting the word 'testing' be the first thing a recruiter reads.
- **Promote and expand the internships.** Deloitte, Sopra Steria, and Capgemini are your Java and Spring Boot credentials, and right now they sit at the bottom of the page. Move them up and give them more space. These bullets are what qualify you for the roles you are targeting.
- **Add a Projects section near the top.** Once your capstone and microservices projects exist, they are your proof of current Java ability. Include the GitHub link, the live demo URL, and one line naming the stack: Java 21, Spring Boot, PostgreSQL, Docker, RabbitMQ.
- **Set your location to 'Montreal, QC (relocating)'**. Do not list Toronto. A Toronto address on a Montreal application is the most common reason a good resume gets filtered out before a human sees it.
- **Add a two-line summary at the top** naming exactly what you are: a bilingual software engineer with a Master of Engineering, backend experience in Java and Spring Boot, targeting backend roles in Montreal.

The rule that protects you: only put on the resume what you can defend under ten minutes of follow-up questions. Before you send anything, re-read each internship bullet and make sure you can explain the design decisions behind it again, not just recite the sentence.

Section 2 — The French Resume

This is your largest structural advantage and most candidates competing with you cannot replicate it. Write a genuine French version — not a machine translation, which Quebec recruiters spot instantly.

- Use the vocabulary Quebec employers use: développeur backend, ingénieur logiciel, architecture logicielle, microservices, base de données relationnelle, tests unitaires.
- French resumes in Quebec follow broadly the same structure as English ones — you are translating content and register, not reformatting.
- Send the French version to any employer whose posting is in French, and to any Quebec-headquartered company even when the posting is in English. It signals you will integrate, not just commute.
- Prepare to interview in French too. Rehearse your project walkthrough and your six behavioural stories in French as well as English — being able to switch mid-interview is a memorable moment.

Section 3 — The 60-Company Target List

Build this as a spreadsheet with columns for company, careers page URL, tier, French required, role found, date applied, resume version sent, status, and follow-up date. Aim for 60 companies across three tiers.

Verify these names and their current hiring status yourself when you build the list — company situations change, and the list above is a starting point for your own research rather than a verified snapshot of who is hiring in October 2026.

Section 4 — LinkedIn and Your Application System

- Headline: 'Java Backend Software Engineer | Spring Boot | Bilingual EN/FR | Montreal'.
- Set your LinkedIn location to Montreal. Recruiters filter by location constantly.
- Turn on 'Open to Work', visible to recruiters only, with backend and software engineer as target titles.
- Rewrite your About section in both languages, leading with backend engineering and your projects.
- Post your capstone project publicly when it ships in Week 6, with the architecture and what you learned. This occasionally reaches hiring managers directly and costs you nothing.
- Build the application tracker before you send application number one. Without it you will lose track of follow-ups, and follow-ups convert.

Application volume targets

Period	Daily target	Cumulative by end
Week 5 (Oct 2-8)	5-8 per day	~40
Week 6 (Oct 9-15)	8 per day	~95
Week 7 (Oct 16-22)	8 per day	~150
Week 8 (Oct 23-29)	8 per day	~205
Week 9 (Oct 30-Nov 5)	8 per day	~260
Weeks 10-11	5 per day	~320

Tailor each application — at minimum, adjust the summary line and reorder skills to match the posting. Mass-sending an identical resume to 300 companies produces a far worse response rate than 150 tailored applications.

Section 5 — Referrals and Recruiters

Referrals convert at several times the rate of cold applications. You have a real network from three internships at large consultancies — many of those people are now spread across Europe and Canada, and some are in Montreal.

- List every former colleague and manager from Capgemini, Deloitte, and Sopra Steria. Check LinkedIn for who is now in Montreal or at a company with a Montreal office.
- Message them directly and specifically: what you are looking for, what you have built recently, and a clear ask for a referral. Vague 'let me know if you hear anything' messages get vague results.
- Contact Montreal-focused technical recruiters and staffing agencies. Even though you want an end-employer role rather than another staffing arrangement, recruiters have direct pipelines into Tier 1 companies.
- Message engineers at your target companies on LinkedIn — not to ask for a job, but to ask one genuine question about their team's stack. A meaningful share of these turn into referrals.

Section 6 — Handling the Relocation Question

You are applying to Montreal roles from Toronto and will not move until an offer is signed. Address this directly rather than hoping it goes unnoticed. Employers rarely reject candidates who state a firm plan; they routinely reject candidates who seem uncertain about moving.

In the first recruiter conversation, say plainly: you are relocating to Montreal, you have already planned the move, and you can be there for an in-person start date. If asked why Montreal, the honest answer — quality of life, and wanting to work in a bilingual environment where your French is an asset rather than unused — is a genuinely good answer. Do not over-explain it.

Section 7 — Behavioural Preparation

Write six stories in STAR format (Situation, Task, Action, Result) and rehearse them out loud in both languages. Your material is genuinely strong here — production incident work teaches you things pure development does not.

- A difficult production incident you investigated and resolved, with the impact quantified.
- A time you improved a process or removed something inefficient.
- A conflict or disagreement with a colleague and how you resolved it.
- A technical decision you made on your capstone and the trade-offs you weighed.
- Something that failed or that you got wrong, and specifically what you changed afterward.
- Why you are moving from QA into backend development — your career narrative, told confidently rather than apologetically.

On that last one: your QA background is an asset, not a weakness to explain away. You have seen how systems actually break in production, which most junior developers have never witnessed. Say that directly — it makes you the candidate who writes defensively because you know what failure looks like.

Section 8 — Interview Process and Take-Homes

- **Before every interview:** 30 minutes of company research, re-read the posting, map your projects onto their stack, and prepare three specific questions to ask them.
- **Screening call:** expect background, motivation, salary expectations, and the relocation question. Have a salary range ready — research Montreal backend salaries beforehand so you are not answering blind.
- **Technical screen:** usually a coding exercise or live Java and Spring questions. Talk through your reasoning out loud; silence reads as being stuck even when you are thinking clearly.
- **Take-home:** return it within 48 hours. Over-deliver on tests, README, and commit hygiene — these are graded more heavily than the feature itself. Take-homes take priority over that day's entire plan.
- **Final round:** system design, architecture discussion, and behavioural. Expect to whiteboard your own project, which is why you rehearsed presenting it.
- **After every interview:** write down every question you were asked. By Week 10 you will have a study list built from real data instead of guesswork.

Section 9 — Offers and Negotiation

- Get every offer in writing before responding substantively.
- Take 24 to 48 hours before accepting, even when you intend to say yes. Nobody withdraws an offer over a reasonable, polite pause.
- If you have multiple live processes, tell the others you have an offer in hand. This compresses their timelines more reliably than anything else you can do.
- Negotiate once, politely, with a specific number and a reason. If base salary is genuinely fixed — common at large Quebec institutions with banded pay scales — negotiate start date, vacation, remote days, or a relocation allowance instead.
- Read the contract carefully before signing, particularly notice periods, non-compete clauses, and intellectual property terms. If anything is unclear or seems unusually broad, have an employment lawyer review it before you sign — I am not a lawyer and this is not legal advice.
- Only after the offer is signed do you book the move.

A Realistic Note on the Numbers

Response rates on cold applications are typically low, which is why the volume targets are high and why referrals matter so much. Around 300 applications, a meaningful number of screening calls, and a smaller number of full loops is the realistic shape of this. That is not pessimism — it is the reason the plan starts applications on October 2 rather than late October, and the reason you keep applying even while interviewing. Volume early is what gives the pipeline time to mature before November 20.